



Ages 11 to 14

Looking After Yourself and Your Friends: Self-Harm and Suicidal Thoughts

Noticing how you feel, ways to cope, how to help a friend, and where to get help. For all students.

Before You Read This guide talks about self-harm and thoughts of suicide.

This guide is about looking after yourself and your friends when feelings get really hard, including self-harm and thoughts of suicide. It doesn't describe anything graphic. Some of it might still feel close to home. That's OK.

- Read it in bits, take a break, or stop whenever you need to.
- You can talk to any adult you trust at school, including the safeguarding team, a counsellor or the school nurse.
- **Childline** is free and confidential. You can call 0800 1111 any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.

If you or someone else is in danger right now, call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

Everyone has hard days. Sometimes feelings get so big that it's difficult to cope. This guide is about **noticing how you feel, finding ways to cope, getting help, and helping a friend.**

- Some people hurt themselves to cope with painful feelings. This is called **self-harm**.
- Some people have thoughts about not wanting to be alive, or about ending their life. These are called **suicidal thoughts**.
- If either of these is happening to you, **you are not alone, you are not in trouble, and help is out there.**

Need Help Now?

- **Tell an adult you trust:** a teacher, your tutor, a house parent or anyone at school you feel safe with.
- If someone has threatened you or someone else, **tell an adult straight away.**
- If you feel like you might hurt yourself, or you're thinking about ending your life, **tell an adult now**, or call **Samaritans** free on 116 123, any time.
- If someone is in danger right now, **call 999.**
- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free, any time.

What Do the Words Mean?

Self-harm

When someone hurts themselves on purpose, usually to cope with feelings that are too much. It's a sign someone needs support.

Suicidal thoughts

Thoughts about not wanting to be alive, or about ending your life. You are not the only person to have them, and they can pass.

Coping

The things you do to get through a hard moment. Some ways of coping help you; some can hurt you.

Trusted adult

An adult you feel safe with: a teacher, tutor, coach, house parent, school nurse, counsellor or family member.

Safety plan

A plan you make with an adult: your warning signs, what helps, and who to contact if things get really bad.

Noticing How You Feel

Feelings are like the weather: they change, even the really heavy ones. It helps to notice when things are getting harder, so you can get support early.

Signs You Might Be Struggling

- Feeling sad, angry, empty or worried most of the time
- Not sleeping well, or sleeping much more than usual
- Not wanting to see friends or do things you used to enjoy

- Feeling like you're a burden, or that nothing will get better
- Wanting to hurt yourself when feelings get too much

It's OK To

- Not be OK sometimes
- Cry, or feel angry, or not know what you feel
- Ask for help, even if you're not sure it's "bad enough"
- Feel worried about exams, friends, home or how you look

Things That Can Help

- **Talk to someone.** A friend, a family member or an adult at school. Saying it out loud can make it feel smaller.
- **Slow your breathing.** Breathe in gently, then breathe out for longer. Do it five times.
- **Move.** A walk, a kick-about, dancing in your room: moving can help big feelings pass.
- **Get your feelings out safely.** Write them down, draw, listen to music, or squeeze something soft.
- **Be with people.** If you feel like hurting yourself, go somewhere with other people around, and tell someone.
- **Look after the basics.** Sleep, food, water and time off screens make a real difference.
- **Use Childline's tools.** The Calm Zone and Coping Kit on [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) have ideas for getting through hard moments.

Different things work for different people. If you're finding it hard to cope, you don't have to work it out on your own: an adult can help you find what works for you.

If You're Having Thoughts of Suicide

You Matter

- Thoughts about not wanting to be alive can be really frightening. **Having them doesn't mean you have to act on them**, and they can pass.

- You don't have to feel this way on your own. **Tell an adult you trust today.** If it feels too hard to say, write it down and give it to them, or show them this page.
- If you feel you can't keep yourself safe right now, **call 999**, or ask someone to take you to A&E.
- You can call **Childline** on 0800 1111 or **Samaritans** on 116 123, free, any time, or text **SHOUT** to 85258.

RESPOND: Helping a Friend

Young people often tell a friend first. That makes you important. But **you are not expected to keep your friend safe on your own.** Your job is to be kind, and to get an adult involved.

You Lead (R, E, S)

R

Recognise

Notice the signs.

- Has your friend gone quiet, stopped doing things, or said things like "I wish I wasn't here"?
- Have you noticed injuries they're hiding, or have they told you they hurt themselves?
- You don't need to be sure to do something

E

Engage

Talk and listen.

- Find a quiet moment: "You don't seem yourself. Are you OK?"
- Listen. You don't need to have the answers
- It's OK to ask: "Are you thinking about suicide?" Asking doesn't put the idea in their head

S

Support

Be there.

- "I'm glad you told me. You're not on your own."
- If they are in danger right now, stay with them if it is safe to do so, and get an adult straight away, or call 999

The Bridge: Pause (P)

P Pause

Stop and think.

- Don't promise to keep it a secret. Their safety matters more than a promise
- You don't have to watch them, check their arms, or sort it out. That's the adults' job

Adults Lead (O, N, D)

O Offer

Show them there's help.

- "Let's talk to someone together. I'll come with you."
- Share the numbers in this guide

N Notify

Tell a trusted adult.

- **Tell an adult, even if your friend asks you not to.** Tell your friend you're going to, if you can
- If they are in danger right now, tell an adult straight away or call 999
- That isn't betraying them. It's how they get help

D Document

Adults write it down.

- The adult will make a record. You just need to tell them what you saw and heard

Look After Yourself Too

Worrying about a friend is heavy. Talk to an adult about how **you** are feeling as well. You can call Childline for yourself, too.

What Happens When You Tell

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with someone you trust.** Behind them is a team whose job is to make sure you get the right help.
- The adult will listen and take what you say seriously.
- If you've hurt yourself, the school nurse can check you, kindly and privately. You won't be in trouble.
- If an adult is worried about your safety, they will share the concern with the school's safeguarding team. They will explain what happens next and involve you as much as possible in decisions about keeping you safe. They won't promise to keep it secret.
- Adults who work with young people are allowed to share information that helps keep children safe without asking your permission. They only share what is needed, and only with the people who need to know. They will tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put someone in danger, and they will listen to what you think.
- You will be kept informed and asked what you need.

Remember

- You won't be told off for telling someone how you feel.
- Your parents or carers will usually be told, because they can help keep you safe. The adults will talk with you about how. If something at home is part of why you feel this way, tell the adult. They will think carefully about how, and whether, your family is told.
- If the first person you tell doesn't help, tell someone else.

Online

- Some content online about self-harm or suicide can make you feel worse. If you see something upsetting, **close it, don't share it, and tell an adult.** You can report it on the app or site.
- If a friend posts or messages something worrying, **tell an adult straight away**, even late at night. If they may be in danger right now, call 999.
- Spending time online when you feel low can make it harder to sleep. Try putting your phone away before bed.

- There is also good support online: Childline's 1-2-1 chat and message boards are safe places to talk. If you need someone straight away, calling 0800 1111 is usually quickest.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"Asking someone about suicide will give them the idea"	Asking directly doesn't put the idea in someone's head. It can help them feel less alone.
"Self-harm is just attention-seeking"	Self-harm is usually a way of coping with painful feelings. Most people hide it. It's a sign someone needs support.
"If a friend asks me to keep it secret, I have to"	If a friend might be in danger, telling an adult is the right thing, even if they asked you not to.
"It's my job to keep my friend safe"	It's not. Tell an adult. Keeping someone safe is the adults' job.
"Telling an adult will make things worse"	Adults will listen, and help make a plan with you. You'll be told what is happening.

If You Board

- **You can always contact your house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.**
- If you feel like hurting yourself, or you're worried about someone in your house, tell a member of staff, **even in the middle of the night.**
- Your boarding school has an independent person you can talk to who isn't a member of staff.
- You can always contact your family privately.

Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor, a teacher, a coach, a house parent if you board, or a school counsellor
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline (for anyone under 19)**: 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **If you're under 18, start here.**
- **Shout**: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- **Samaritans**: 116 123, free from any phone, any time, day or night, whatever your age
- **NHS 111**: call 111 and choose the mental health option (option 2), for urgent mental health help in England, any time, or use NHS 111 online. An adult can call for you
- **Emergency**: call 999

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RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

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